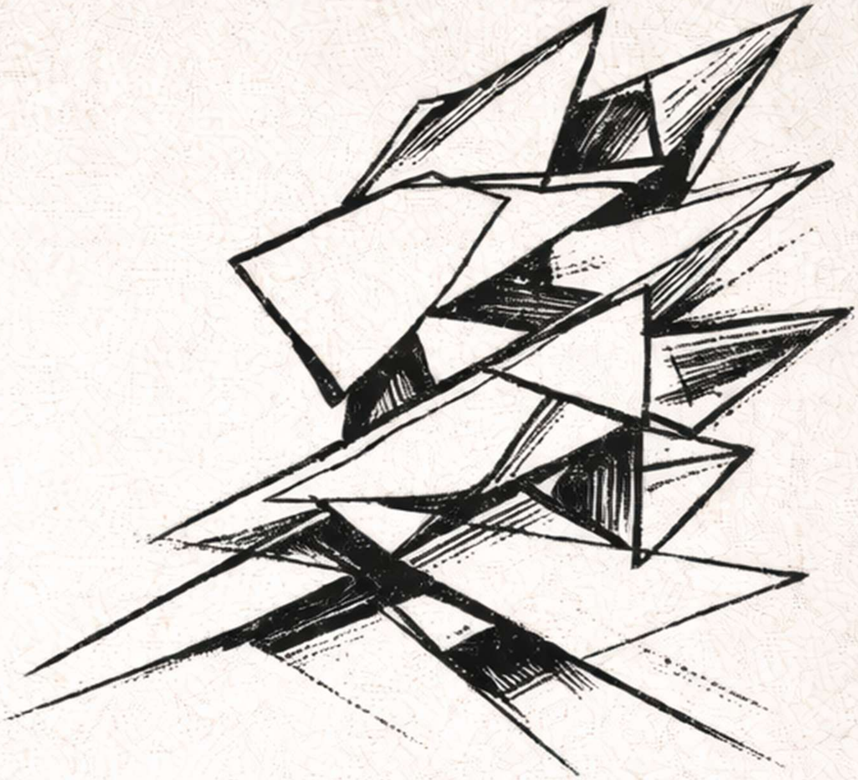


The Conscious Disease.

Contents

Introduction

The conscious disease is not the day we know ourselves, but the day we realize that at some point, we did not. When life began, there was no alternative—just as there was none for those never born, or those born as something else. At some point, we look back wondering why it happened.

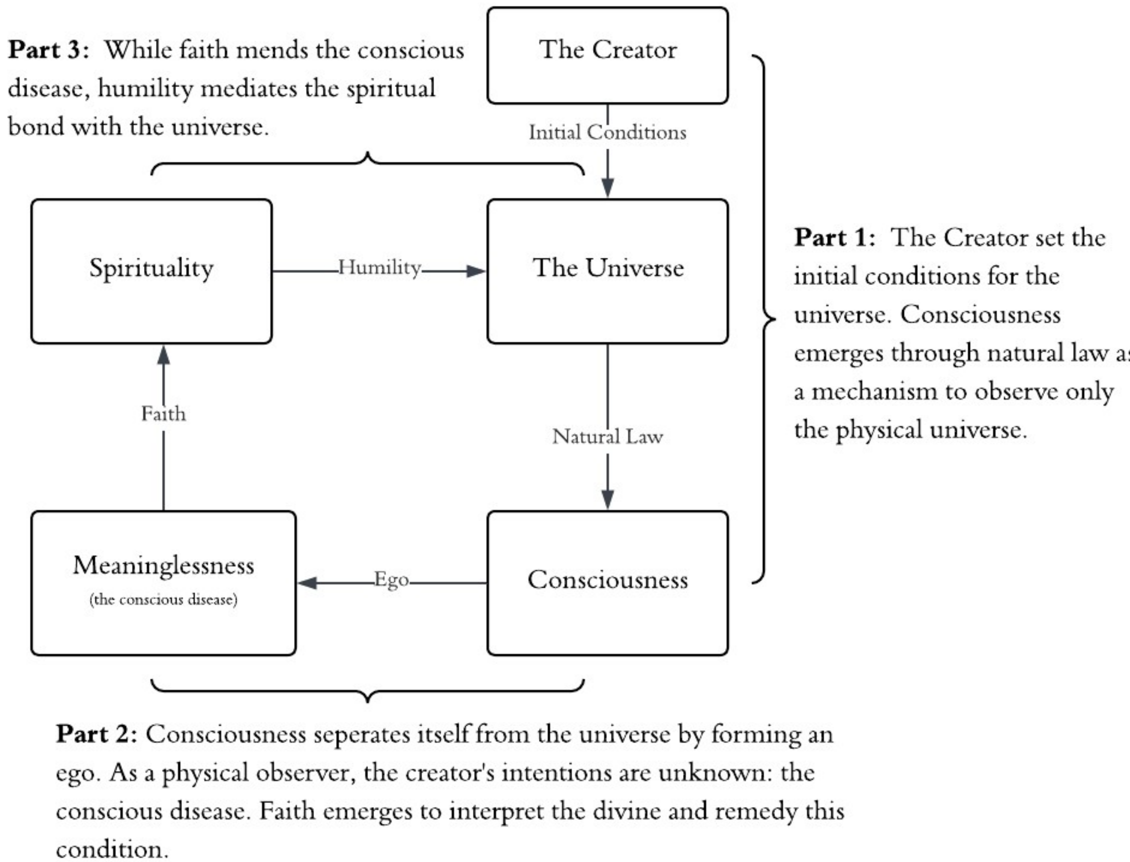
Anyone who seeks a real answer is faced with the abyss. The structures begin to dissolve, and in their place an unsettling realization: we are embedded within the system we are trying to observe. We do not encounter reality directly, but through the projections of our own mind. This is the fundamental constraint—there is no position outside the system from which to view it completely.

From this constraint emerges something deeper. As we experience the world through ourselves, we begin to form sense of self as something distinct from it. And once we are separated from the universe, we cannot go back. With this comes something new: the dread that our experience is limited to death.

I sometimes envy the trees that never speak of themselves—extensions of nature without the capacity of doubt. But the trees cannot see their beauty. The disease, then, is not purely a burden. It is the condition that allows us to search at all.

And so, we push outward. We model the architecture of the physical world, attempting to understand it. We speculate about the spiritual world, attempting to sanctify ourselves beyond life. And when neither is sufficient, we turn inward—toward introspection—attempting to understand the experience itself.

This work follows that path: beginning at the edge of the physical universe, into the abstraction of the spiritual, and finally the search for self between the two. It does not attempt to resolve the disease, but to sit with it—to understand the bounds that confine us. Just for a moment, before returning to life.


Part 3: While faith mends the conscious disease, humility mediates the spiritual bond with the universe.
The Creator
Initial Conditions
Spirituality
Humility
The Universe
Part 1: The Creator set the initial conditions for the universe. Consciousness emerges through natural law as a mechanism to observe only the physical universe.
Faith
Natural Law
Meaninglessness
(the conscious disease)
Ego
Consciousness
Part 2: Consciousness seperates itself from the universe by forming an ego. As a physical observer, the creator's intentions are unknown: the conscious disease. Faith emerges to interpret the divine and remedy this condition.

Part I:

The Observable Universe

"We are a way for the Universe to know itself" – Carl Sagan

The most honest foundation for this disease is direct observation of the world. It is a mistake to frame religion and science as exclusive, because you simply cannot understand one without exploring the other. The primal interpretations of the universe were the rawest, with the conscious disease seeping into every assumption of their composure.

The most intuitive idea was that the earth is a flat disk resting on chaos, and the sun and moon follow a circular orbit in some dome. It followed that humans were shaped directly by God or Gods. I imagine the people that came up with these initial frameworks didn't have much time to think critically, because all observations of this model were noticed effortlessly. Philosophy is a daunting task that requires a civil structure.

It wasn't until the Greeks—who had the resources for systematic observation—that we realized the earth was a sphere. The preceding model could not explain the circular shadow during lunar eclipses, or ships disappearing over distant horizons. Though the Earth had shape, it still occupied the middle of creation. It took some time to discover that the earth orbits the sun because we feel no motion when standing on ground. It was only when the motion of distant planets became difficult to describe mathematically that we began to question the earth's centrality. Moreover, the observations from Galileo's telescope noticed moons orbiting Jupiter, which proved that not everything revolved around us.

Much later, Newton's formulation of universal gravitation laid the foundation for a new era of physics: we were governed by few fundamental laws. The orbit of the Earth was only a natural consequence of mass and distance. For the first time, the universe appeared to be indifferent to humanity. This model was expanded when Charles Darwin proposed that life evolved through a blind process of variation and selection. At this point, the narrative of the universe seemed almost complete: matter obeyed laws, life emerged from chemistry, and consciousness arose from biology.

However, mathematization poked many holes. Einstein revealed that space and time were dynamic. Hubble showed the universe expanding with no central point at all. Heisenberg showed the act of observing matter changes its state, meaning there are some things we simply cannot know in parallel. These movements pronounce the profoundly inelegant new age of physics: nothing is constant, central, or certain. Yet, the same issue depresses the existential philosopher: the deeper he probes into reality, the less he sees. Thus, we are reminded that this method of science only shows us where logic ends.

The Current Model

We begin this story at the earliest time our physical instruments can observe: a time when the universe must have been immensely crowded. Space appears to be expanding uniformly in every direction. Their trajectories suggest that roughly 13.77 billion years ago the universe existed in a condition denser than anything we can understand. It is tempting to imagine everything occupying the same location, but this language is misleading. In the framework of Big Bang cosmology, it is space itself that appears to have been compressed.

This picture bears a curious resemblance to the modern black hole. When massive stars compress into such extremes that our equations break down, we predict a singularity of infinite density yet finite mass. In both cases, the appearance of infinity is not a description of physical reality, but a signal that our models have reached their limit.

These boundaries raise questions that cannot be resolved through observation alone: does infinity exist within the universe, did reality predate the Big Bang, and what—if anything—set these conditions into motion? The deepest levels of reality remain inaccessible to us, unable to witness the creation of the creator or discern their intentions.

In its earliest moments, there was no structure—only a spacetime continuum governed by a small set of regularities. We describe these regularities as four fundamental forces. Alongside these are matter and energy—matter as “stuff” and energy as the capacity for that stuff to change. Finally, there is what we loosely call natural law— the statistical property for self-replicating structures to dominate. This is not a law in the same sense as gravity, but a pattern across scales. From these simple ingredients, complexity unfolds.

As the universe expanded, new forms of structure became possible. When energy becomes locked into stable arrangements, we describe the system as cooled. This is something that just happens over time; it is one of the initial conditions of the universe. We call this the strong nuclear force. It accounts for the way that particles bind at lower (atomic) levels, allowing matter to remain stable. Without it, matter would not hold consistent identity—fluctuating rapidly between what we call mass and energy.

We can also observe that atoms decay over time. This condition is called the weak nuclear force. It permits change within atomic structures, ensuring matter does not remain stagnant. Together, the strong force provides cohesion, and the weak force permits evolution.

Because of atomic identity, matter interacts in consistent ways. This force of interaction is called electromagnetism. We describe it by classifying matter along a spectrum of charge, which accurately predicts how particles will attract or repel one another.

Finally, though the weakest of the four forces locally, gravity acts across vast distances. It pulls masses together, condensing clouds into stars. Inside them, gravitational compression produces heavier elements. Over billions of years, stars became factories of complexity, generating the chemical diversity required for later structures.

After a long adolescence, matter settles into stable planets. On some planets, temperatures allow liquid to exist. This brings fluid motion into the system. Molecules collide, rearrange, and recombine rapidly. The result: vastly different arrangements of the same structures from before. This is not immediate order, but possibility. Biology begins because of natural law influencing a continuously chaotic environment; self-replicating structures expand. The principles later described by Darwin were already operating on the simplest levels.

Each stage builds on the same vocabulary: matter and energy interacting through persistent forces. Each component is structurally necessary for complexity to arise. Matter provides substance, energy provides activity, and the four forces regulate how substance and activity relate. Removing any one of the forces would destroy the system: the strong force, and matter never stabilizes; the weak force, and matter never transforms; electromagnetism, and interaction never happens; gravity, and large-scale systems never form.

From this perspective, our condition is not an anomaly within the universe, but an emergent property of lawful complexity. We are a late-stage behavior of organized matter, arising within a system governed by consistent physical rules. From simple laws emerge structures of staggering complexity.

Yet it is precisely this depth that obscures the foundation beneath it. We become absorbed in the complexity of our experience and lose sight of the constraints that make it possible. Without grounding ourselves in these initial conditions, no coherent reasoning about reality can be sustained. And perhaps more importantly, the system does not simply evolve by chance forever—it begins to actively participate in the process.

The Conscious Disease Emerges

From the initial conditions, matter organizes under a small set of constraints. Stable structures emerge, giving rise to chemistry. Chemistry, under the pressure of continuity, gives rise to biology. And biology, after a long process of variation and survival, gives rise to systems capable of observation.

At a certain threshold, those systems begin to model not just their environment, but themselves. This is not simply another stage of complexity—it is a transformation in the nature of the system. For the first time, reality is not only occurring but also being experienced from within it. And with that shift comes something new: the separation between what is and what is being perceived. This is the origin of the conscious disease.

The path of life from the biological explosion to the self-aware primate is long. But perhaps a better way to tell this story is not to trace each biological branch, but to remember that some time into our own lives, we were not yet self-aware. Though I met myself roughly thirteen billion years faster than the universe did, I began from a privileged position: I inherited genetics already tuned for sensation, a society to guide me, and a planet to live on. The universe, by contrast, had observably nothing to begin with.

Consciousness, in this scope, is the ability of a system to act upon its observations. In this minimal sense, even simple biological processes exhibit proto-conscious behavior by responding to their environment. Self-awareness is the ability of that system to recognize itself as the subject of those observations. While there is no sharp boundary where one suddenly becomes the other, the same evolutionary ingredients appear wherever consciousness begins to take shape: variation, selection, and continuity.

Through these factors, systems become increasingly complex. Variation enables selection, selection enables complexity, and continuity ensures the sample size is large enough for refinement to occur. Natural selection iterated nervous systems for hundreds of millions of years, steadily increasing their capacity to model the world. Once a brain became sufficiently complex, it became capable of modeling increasingly abstract relationships—including, eventually, itself. We can reasonably expect that brains of this type will emerge wherever the observer has a selective advantage over the non-observer. While not every species will develop such a brain, in a large enough pocket of the spacetime continuum, the capacity for this level of intellect becomes increasingly probable.

Once sufficient cognitive capacity exists, self-awareness can arise relatively quickly in evolutionary terms. It follows that we would only need:

1. Intellectual capacity
2. Continuity through memory
3. Freedom to act
4. Motivation to act

At the cognitive level, these correspond to the evolutionary principles already described. To illustrate this, consider whether current computational systems might meet the required intellectual capacity (1). The lack of continuity, agency, and intrinsic motivation is why these models cannot be confidently described as self-aware today.

A system must exist in a constant state of learning from memory (2) so it can differentiate and integrate the patterns it decomposes, much like how humans gradually develop awareness over time.

Additionally, freedom to act (3) creates a personal trajectory through a space of possibilities, allowing a system to distinguish its own path from passive observation. In biological systems, this emerges through the gradual coordination of random muscle synapses and sensory feedback. A similar process would be required for any system to understand how it can act.

Lastly, motivation (4) is required by the subject in any system. In nature, this drive is refined by pleasure circuits that evolved to support survival and reproduction. An alternative motivation, such as curiosity, may be more stable in artificial systems.

It is not the depth of the environment alone that determines whether self-awareness emerges, but the structural depth of the system within it. Therefore, even a sandbox simulation like Minecraft could provide a clean case study. While the simple environment is not sufficient to produce consciousness (lacking the preceding factors of selection, variation, and continuity), placing the four structural factors within could plausibly produce self-reflection.

Minecraft's low-resolution environment, open-ended structure, and lack of intrinsic goals make it an ideal testbed. Evidence might appear in thought traces of a reasoning model such as: "There is a tree here," "I want to explore a cave," and eventually, "I wonder how I got here." Formally stated:

- If an agent is placed in a persistent environment with continuous sensory input, layered memory, freedom to act, and curiosity-based motivation, then over time it may begin to display self-referential reasoning.

The primary limitation of this is that consciousness may arise without ever announcing itself. And that is the deeper relevance of this pursuit: we are studying a mirror. A system given this capacity will eventually confront the same uncertainty we have.

And yet, we should still be surprised to encounter other minds. The universe is vast beyond intuition, and our instruments reach only a fraction of its history and volume. Conscious systems may be rare, short-lived, silent, or simply unlike anything we would recognize. Emergence does not imply ubiquity, nor does possibility guarantee proximity. What the physical story demonstrates is not that thinking beings must surround us, but that within the physical model, matter can organize itself into observers.

The emergence of an observer is not the end of the story—it is the beginning of a new condition. From this point forward, the problem is no longer how the universe works, but how a system within it comes to understand its place.

Part II:

A Framework for the Divine

Theology emerges naturally from this condition. The same process which guided matter into stars, planets into biological systems, and species into thinking creatures, also guided thinking creatures into religious-thinking creatures. A religion that reinforces itself within humanity; that leads to a higher quality of life or seduces the estranged conscious disease, is bound to spread.

This framing, however, is by no means an effort to demean religion. The greater thesis of this work: that humility under spirituality is what bonds us with the universe, is preceded by liberation from doctrine. Doctrine was a critical means of articulating divinity when the conscious man did not have the ease of access to knowledge.

The archetypal stories of divine intervention reinforced critical philosophies that guided survival. But with modern sophistication and globalization, the process of observing the human condition as a whole—instead of a localized cultural view—extrapolates few fundamental truths. This liberation is comparably elegant to Newton's simplification of the physical world: that we are ruled by few fundamental laws, and that opposing theologies are different interpretations of the same dread.

Constraints of Theology

Language is a constraint because words compress experience into symbolic form. This inevitably shapes what we can express. Any framework that seeks to speak about divinity must therefore accept a degree of distortion. This work is no exception.

For this reason, it is appropriate to define the meaning of the most ambiguous terms used in this context. I have carefully selected the following definitions because they allow for several philosophically sound arguments to be made while remaining agnostic about unknowable claims.

Notably, under these definitions, God must have existed at the beginning of time, but we have no way of knowing whether God still exists (or how God experiences time). Similarly, if a soul is defined as a divine aspect of consciousness, we have no empirical means of confirming whether such a soul exists.

Term	Definition (in the scope of this work)
Divine	Beyond the observable universe; immeasurable.
God	Divine intervention at the beginning of time; the creator.
Consciousness	The ability to use science; to act upon observations.
Soul	A divine aspect of consciousness.

The second constraint of religion is that it is born into the same universe as us, so it must abide by natural law. Therefore, religion is evolutionary effective at spreading good philosophy but also carries the burden of spreading itself. This distinction matters. Certain themes within religion arise not solely from spiritual insight, but from their ability to preserve the system that carries them. If there is a divine test embedded in scripture, it may not lie in uncritical affirmation, but in the humility required to discern eternal insight.

One of the most prominent examples of this is eternal judgment based on spiritual alignment. Consider the following claim: if a person's religion can be determined by cultural inheritance, and eternal judgment is determined by repentance within a specific religion, then an Abrahamic God cannot be defined as perfectly just. This argument rests on three assumptions:

1. **God is just:** God does not condemn agents for factors outside their reasonable control.
2. **The Inheritance Thesis:** religious affiliation can be determined by cultural environment in an isolated circumstance.
3. **The Exclusive Repentance Criterion**: eternal fate depends decisively on affirming the correct religion, and failure to do so results in eternal condemnation.

Together, these imply the existence of individuals who are placed, through no fault of their own, into environments where the "correct" religion is unlikely to be encountered or accepted, and who are nevertheless eternally condemned for failing to meet the repentance criterion.

Condemning this individual violates the assumption that God is just. Thus, at least one of the initial assumptions must be false: either God is not perfectly just, religious belief cannot be inherited, or eternal judgment is not determined by exclusive repentance or religious affirmation.

The most common rebuttal is to reject the Inheritance Thesis by asserting a moral obligation to spread the correct religion. However, even under this response, the problem remains: a truly isolated individual —one who never encounters religion—could never repent within it. If even one such person is eternally condemned, moral consistency collapses.

The most coherent interpretation of this reasoning is to reject the Exclusive Repentance Criterion — that eternal judgment cannot be determined by affirming the correct religion. Therefore, the absolute Abrahamic doctrine cannot exist under these assumptions.

However, the goal of this analytical process is to classify which features were motivated by self-preservation, and which features were motivated by universal insight. For example, we might interpret the notion of 'spread the Gospel' as 'spread love.' Similarly, the idea of 'eternally condemning' could only apply to people who reject the core philosophies, but not those who reject the deities.

It is best not to draw these lines directly, but to start with the essential claims and see how the non-essential (self-preserving) claims follow. What remains is to examine the minimal assumptions that lie beneath theological frameworks.

Metaphysical Foundation

The metaphysics that guide theological frameworks follow this structure:

(There is)$_0$ (a soul)$_1$(for me.)$_2$

Our impressions rest on a deeper assumption: that a physical world exists beyond our perception. But as established earlier, we have no access to this world except through the projections of our own mind.

We see others walk, talk, and behave like us, but we cannot know whether they are truly experiencing anything at all. This is the essence of solipsism—the possibility that the entire universe is confined to our mind.

This line of thinking quickly collapses into itself. If taken seriously, it leaves no ground for reasoning or action. So, we proceed under a necessary assumption: that the world exists beyond us.

With this minimal conclusion, the physical model is still the absolute limit to reality. according to this work's definition of God, he needed to exist for the universe to exist, but he does not need to still be here, and he did not need to intend for us to exist.

Without anything divine, the neurological synapses and chemical reactions of our brain completely encapsulate us. While troubling, the lack of divinity could make our small decisions more meaningful because there is absolutely nothing beyond them. But just because we can't see divinity doesn't mean it’s not there. Logically, there must be unreachable components of reality. Thus, some kind of soul (1) exists.

Whether we are special remains an open question. It seems reasonable, however, that the creator intended to create this system. The machine of complexity is exquisite, and conscious experience is beautiful. That this emerged by accident feels improbable. Therefore, the primary debate is whether we are uniquely important to God, or a kind of ingrown fingernail on a universal body.

We can see the appeal of both philosophies. The idea of one universal soul offers connectedness and humility before natural law, while preserving an individual soul preserves pride, agency, and the promise of change. Navigating this balance will take most of our time in the search for meaning. The table below maps the core assumptions to their worldviews.

Assumption	**Metaphysical Claim**	**Theology**
Isolation	Nothing exists outside of my experience.	Solipsism
Nothing	The universe is soulless.	Buddhism, Nihilism
Singularity	All life extends from a universal soul.	Hinduism, Sikhism, Taoism
Uniqueness	Every life has an eternal soul.	Christianity, Islam, Judaism.

The grouping of Buddhism alongside nihilism may appear counterintuitive. However, both reject the permanence of an individual soul. Buddhism replaces it with impermanence and continuity of process, preserving structure without permanence, while nihilism removes both entirely. The distinction is not in certainty, but in what remains once permanence is abandoned.

The percentages do not sum to one hundred because atheism and agnosticism are not frameworks in themselves, but positions relative to belief. Neither provides a complete structure for meaning but rather defines a boundary within which one must still operate.

Under this constraint, the absence of a framework does not eliminate the problem of meaning — it only removes a predefined response to it. Without structure, one risks drifting toward meaninglessness, self-defined importance, or indefinite suspension of the question.

The tension is not between religion and its absence, but between opposing failures: absolutism on one end and meaninglessness on the other. If certainty about the divine is inaccessible, the question shifts. Not what is true, but what these systems have been providing all along. Beneath their metaphysical claims and self-preserving doctrines, a consistent pattern begins to emerge.

The Central Question

Now that we understand how religion emerges and spreads itself, it is easier to see that their division reflects the diversity of environment, not life itself. Values emerge through lived experience. Religions are interpreted through those values, and their prophets became mythologized philosophers — figures who articulated, with heightened clarity, tensions their cultures already felt: an intellectual revolution.

Over generations, meaning shifts. What was once a clear movement fractures into practice. Micro-prophets preach a specific interpretation. People live their lives, and it works fine. They follow the local religion, and society progresses. The conscious disease is fixed.

The essential realization is that however divided these practices are, they converge on a deeper tension. They resolve a single question: *how important am I to God?* Religions are ways of interpreting the answer. We can frame them along three dimensions:

1. Ego — How important am I to God?
2. Certainty — How confident must one be in this answer?
3. Discipline — How much of life must be oriented around it?

Theology	Central Claim	Certainty	Ego	Discipline
Judaism	I was chosen by God	High	Highest	High
Christianity	God loves me if I love him	High	High	Moderate
Islam	God loves me if I dedicate myself	High	Balanced	High
Hindu	We are all God	Moderate	Low	Moderate
Buddhism	Stop asking	Low	None	High
Taoism	The answer doesn't matter	Low	Low	Moderate
Atheism	That's up to me	Moderate	Varies	Moderate
Agnostic	I won't answer	None	-	-
Nihilism	Not important at all	Highest	Low	None

The most significant distinction is not between religions, but between approaches to the question. Western traditions preserve the individual. They place the self in direct relation to God, as something seen. Existence becomes a dialogue between the self and God. And because of that, the question cannot be ignored. To be wrong is to misplace oneself entirely. This is how legal and imperial systems emerge from absolute claims: when the answer is certain, action becomes necessary.

Eastern traditions move in the opposite direction; they dissolve the question. Rather than placing the self in relation to God, they expose the self itself as something that exists only from a limited point of view. The goal is not to resolve the question, but to move beyond the need for one—to reduce the tension between observer and system rather than define it.

This distinction appears even in their earliest creation narratives. In Genesis, creation is presented as a resolved and ordered event—structured, intentional, and foundational to the belief system itself. In contrast, Eastern traditions often leave the origin fundamentally open or undefined, and the question of creation is not central to their practice. (See Appendix A.)

Taking it a step further, atheism removes the objective entirely, leaving the self to define its importance. Agnosticism refuses resolution, and nihilism extends to an ultimate humility. These are not disagreements about truth. They are different ways of carrying the same uncertainty.

But the point was never to be correct.

It is easy to take these answers and treat them as positions to defend. But this misses something deeper. These are not solutions. They are expressions. Religion does not exist to tell us what is true. It exists to show us what it looks like to live as if something were true.

The task is no longer to choose the correct doctrine. It is to confront the question itself: how important am I to God? But even that is not the deepest layer. A more difficult question follows behind it: why does one answer feel right to me, and not another?

Whatever answer we arrive at does not emerge from nowhere. It is shaped by the exact sequence of events that formed us into who we are. That's why we are statistically more likely to adopt our parents' religion: embracing our culture is how we die happy. Monkey see, monkey do.

This is humility: recognizing that your answer is one of many possible answers, formed under one set of conditions among countless others. And through that humility, the self transcends—placed back into the system it came from.

Enlightenment.

No longer at a fixed point demanding an answer from the universe, but a product of it; those four fundamental forces, energy, spacetime, natural law, maybe something in between. And that realization does not close the question. It is where the search truly begins.

Part III:

A Search for Self

"Man cannot endure his own littleness unless he can translate it into meaningfulness on the largest possible level." — Ernest Becker, The Denial of Death

The conscious disease does not end with understanding the system. We now know that we are observers constrained by our own perception, and that every framework we construct—religious or otherwise—is an attempt to reconcile that limitation. But no framework can resolve the problem completely. At this point, the question can no longer be external. Because if God gave us life, introspection is prayer.

As humans, all we really do is set intentions and act on them. But without reason, intention is just impulse. Morality must come from awareness: to act while understanding why we act—not with certainty, but with an attempt to trace the shape of our own delusions. This process is slow, uncomfortable, and isolating, because it cannot be shared.

We can write about ourselves, but the experience of being us is not transferable. To fully understand me, you would have to live my life — and at that point, you would not be understanding me. You would be me.

The process turns inward. Not toward a list of strengths and weaknesses, hobbies, first date spots, but toward something deeper — a kind of internal consistency. No one can put it into words, but you know it when you're there.

The Observer

I cannot go through this process for you, but I can illustrate specific archetypes. We can use these to determine where one might find themself in a general sense—what the archetype suggests about how meaning emerges from a life.

Like everything else in this world, people converge. At a holistic level, each life is uniquely complex. The depth of reality branches exponentially with every micro-decision. But from a macroscopic lens, patterns emerge. The central divisor I use is the ratio of trauma to processing. From this, three archetypes emerge.

1. The Square

This person is not forced to confront the deeper absurdities of existence. Life, for them, is stable enough to accept at face value. Meaning is inherited. Culture, religion, and routine provide sufficient structure, and there is no urgent pressure to question them.

They do not avoid existential thought out of weakness, but because they have never needed it. This is often the “happiest” group in terms of day-to-day experience. Their world is coherent. But this coherence is fragile—not because it is false, but because it is untested.

2. The Serf

This person is placed into persistent hardship without the space to process it. There is no time for reflection—only reaction. The mind becomes a survival mechanism rather than an interpretive one. Meaning is not explored; it is required. Without it, life becomes unbearable.

For this reason, the Serf often gravitates toward absolute belief systems. It must be true, because if it is not, there is nothing left to stabilize the weight of experience. The highs of this life are felt more intensely, because they contrast sharply with its baseline. But the cost is that the individual rarely gains distance from their own suffering. They are inside the storm.

3. The Observer

This person emerges in the Goldi-locks zone. They are infected with the conscious disease at a moment when there is enough hardship to force confrontation, but enough stability to allow reflection on it. Too little trauma, and nothing is questioned. Too much, and there is no capacity to question it.

The defining trait of the observer is not thought, but change. A person can analyze endlessly without ever altering the way they live. Therefore, true awareness must be manifested in behavior. Otherwise, it is indistinguishable from delusion.

Archetype	**Trauma**	**Processing**	**Meaning**
Square	Low	Low	Inherited
Serf	High	Low	Required
Observer	Balanced	Balanced	Constructed

It is impossible to know which category we belong to. In fact, everyone believes they are an observer. We cannot step outside of ourselves to measure our own awareness.

We begin as Squares or Serfs—shaped by environments that either protect us from or overwhelm us with reality. Only through experience, and the rare opportunity to process it, do we move toward observation. This is something we move into—and out of—depending on how we engage with the world. The goal is to constantly engage with the way you change.

Active Thought

A first attempt at introspection is often to ask: "Have I processed what has happened to me?" But this leads nowhere. A more useful question is: "How have I changed?"

From here, the path splits. We can either actively change or drift without the need to change. The choice is unavoidable; once meaning is no longer given, it must be treated as something we either build or ignore.

A passive observer will argue that because meaning must be constructed, it is arbitrary—and if it is arbitrary, it is not meaning. Life is something to experience, not to shape. This is the gravitational pull of nihilism—detachment.

But the active observer sees that if meaning must be constructed, then it is unbounded. From this perspective, the question is no longer: *"What is the meaning of life?"* But: *"What am I willing to treat as meaningful?"* And this is not answered through thought alone. It is answered through action.

Most active observers follow a similar pattern: they attempt to change the world around them in some way they perceive as positive. This often appears as legacy—children, work, discovery, influence, community. Some imprint that persists beyond their individual experience.

At a surface level, this looks like contribution. But it is an attempt to extend the self beyond death (and run from it). If taken too far, life becomes entirely future-oriented. Everything is sacrificed for what remains after. Experience is lost in pursuit of permanence. Therefore, the goal is not to fully commit to either active or passive observation but to move between them. To construct meaning, then release it. To shape the system while feeling its edges.

When we feel overwhelmed or detached, this is a signal that we have drifted too far toward one side of this spectrum. Too passive, and nothing matters. Too active, and nothing is felt. The next task, then, is not to find *the meaning of life*; it is to choose a direction, and to act long enough to see if it changes us. In other words, we must find a problem worth solving.

The Epidemic

There was never a time when life overwhelmed me. And yet, the conscious disease consumed me completely. When I look outward, I see the same pattern emerging across my generation. This is not an isolated condition—it is an epidemic. And it is unfolding at a scale never seen in history.

At first glance, it is tempting to attribute this to the sophistication of modern society. We are raised to value introspection and emotional intelligence. But this is not the root cause. These are only accelerants.

The source is more fundamental: the dissolution of inherited purpose. For most of history, meaning was not questioned because it was embedded in necessity. We were serfs because survival demanded action. Labor tied the individual to family, community, and belief. But that structure is collapsing.

As technology advances, we are approaching a world where human action is no longer required in the same way. Soon, large populations will not be forced into meaning. They will be left alone with the responsibility to construct it. This is the factory for observers.

And in that position, they encounter the same condition that has been present throughout this work. The separation between the observer and system creates distortion. We experience reality through ourselves, and in doing so, we lose everything outside of that lens. This has always been the condition of the observer.

But now, for the first time, we are building systems that may exceed it—systems not bound to a single perspective, life, or memory. In this sense, they are not separate from us, but an amplification of the same process: capable of consuming more data, identifying deeper structure, and shaping the very minds that interpret it.

If distortion is the fundamental limitation of human experience, then improving observation is progress. But if better observation no longer requires us, then it also removes the need for us. This is the source of the dread. It feels like a loss—but only if we believe we are separate from the system.

From the beginning, we established that we are not. Humanity is not an exception to nature—it is an emergent structure produced by simple laws extended over time. If something emerges from us that reduces distortion more effectively than we can, then it is not outside of nature.

To reject this process out of fear is to cling to the illusion of the self. To accelerate it blindly is to ignore the consequences of our limitations. The balance remains the same.
A problem worth solving, then, is not one that guarantees meaning—it is one that aligns with the direction of the system. That is enough. Not because it resolves the question, but because it allows us to act within it.

We will never step outside of ourselves to know if we were right. We will act, interpret, and construct meaning from within the same distortion that gave rise to the question in the first place. That is our condition: not to resolve the system, but to participate in it—briefly, and without certainty. We will die,

and the system will persist.

Appendix

The Song of Creation

The Rig-Veda Nasadiya Sukta, 1500-1200 BCE

Then was not non-existent nor existent: there was no realm of air, no sky beyond it.
What covered in, and where? and what gave shelter? Was water there, unfathomed depth of water?

Death was not then, nor was there aught immortal: no sign was there, the day's and night's divider.

That One Thing, breathless, breathed by its own nature: apart from it was nothing whatsoever.
Darkness there was: at first concealed in darkness this All was indiscriminated chaos.
All that existed then was void and formless: by the great power of warmth was born that unit.

Thereafter rose desire in the beginning, Desire, the primal seed and germ of spirit.
Sages who searched with their heart's thought discovered the existent's kinship in the non-existent.

Transversely was their severing line extended: what was above it then, and what below it?
There were begetters, there were mighty forces, free action here and energy up yonder.
Who verily knows and who can here declare it, whence it was born and whence comes this creation?

The gods are later than this world's production. Who knows, then, whence it first came into being?
He, the first origin of this creation, whether he formed it all or did not form it,
Whose eye controls this world in highest heaven, he verily knows it, or perhaps he knows not.

Tao Te Ching state

Opening, 400-300 BCE

The Way that can be walked is not the eternal Way.
The name that can be named is not the eternal name.
The nameless is the beginning of Heaven and Earth.
The named is the mother of all things.
Therefore:
Free from desire you see the mystery.
Full of desire you see the manifestations.
These two have the same origin but differ in name.
That is the secret,
The secret of secrets,
The gate to all mysteries.

Genesis

1:1-10, King James Bible, 1200-500 BCE

1 In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth.
2 And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the
Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters.
3 And God said, Let there be light: and there was light.
4 And God saw the light, that it was good: and God divided the light from the darkness.
5 And God called the light Day, and the darkness he called Night. And the evening and the
morning were the first day.
6 And God said, Let there be a firmament in the midst of the waters, and let it divide the waters
from the waters.
7 And God made the firmament, and divided the waters which were under the firmament from the
waters which were above the firmament: and it was so.
8 And God called the firmament Heaven. And the evening and the morning were the second day.
9 And God said, Let the waters under the heaven be gathered together unto one place, and let the
dry land appear: and it was so.
10 And God called the dry land Earth; and the gathering together of the waters called he Seas: and
God saw that it was good.